



No Bird in Charge

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

The article, marked for rhetorical devices (one color throughout):

1 At dusk in late autumn the starlings gather above their roost and begin to move as one body. There may be a thousand of them, or fifty thousand. The flock **climbs, folds, pours sideways, thins to a gray ribbon, knots into a fist** [Asyndeton]. **It has no leader.** [Telegraphic sentence] No single bird decides the shape, and none is told it.

2 How a crowd that large turns without colliding was a real puzzle until recently. The current answer is that each bird is not watching the whole flock at all, but only its handful of nearest neighbors, about seven of them, matching their speed and heading whatever the distance between them. A turn begun at one edge passes inward, neighbor to neighbor, so a ripple of banking can cross the entire flock faster than any one starling flies. The order is real, and it is built entirely from the bottom.

3 The effect is sharpest when a predator arrives. **A peregrine falcon stoops at the edge, and the flock answers not by scattering but by tightening, the threatened side pulling inward so fast it darkens like a bruise spreading under skin.** [Simile] **Thousands of separate animals, and not one collision; total panic, and perfect order.** [Antithesis] The falcon, built to pick a single target, loses the single target in the boil of bodies.

4 Why they do it at all is not fully settled. The safety of the crowd is part of it, surely; but researchers have also tied the evening gatherings **to warmth, to the trading of word about where the food was that day, to the simple pull of a good roost, and to reasons no one has yet named** [Parallelism]. The murmuration is not a decision and not a message. It is what happens when ten thousand small rules, each followed by a bird watching only its neighbors, add up in the cold air over a winter field.

5 From the ground it looks like a single mind choosing where to go. **There is no mind, and there is nothing choosing; there is only each bird, and its seven neighbors, and the dusk coming on.** [Polysyndeton]

Devices, and why they are here:

Asyndeton (paragraph 1): “climbs, folds, pours sideways, thins to a gray ribbon, knots into a fist”
The piled verbs with the conjunctions stripped out (climbs, folds, pours sideways, thins to a gray ribbon, knots into a fist) speed the line so its rhythm imitates the quick, continuous changing of the flock. Dropping the and's is asyndeton; compare the deliberate opposite in the final paragraph.

Telegraphic sentence (paragraph 1): “It has no leader.”

It has no leader is four words, dropped hard after a long accumulating sentence. The telegraphic sentence lands the central fact of the whole piece with maximum emphasis precisely because it is so short against what comes before it.

Simile (paragraph 3): “A peregrine falcon stoops at the edge, and the flock answers not by scattering but by tightening, the threatened side pulling inward so fast it darkens like a bruise spreading under skin.”

Darkens like a bruise spreading under skin compares the fast inward turn of the threatened flock to a spreading bruise. The like makes it a simile, not a metaphor, and it is chosen for precision: it renders the speed and the spreading at once, without claiming the birds are hurt.

Antithesis (paragraph 3): “Thousands of separate animals, and not one collision; total panic, and perfect order.”

Thousands of separate animals, and not one collision; total panic, and perfect order is built on two opposed pairs held in balance. It is antithesis rather than plain parallelism because the force of the line is the contradiction it names: chaos and order in the same instant.

Parallelism (paragraph 4): “to warmth, to the trading of word about where the food was that day, to the simple pull of a good roost, and to reasons no one has yet named”

The series to warmth, to the trading of word..., to the simple pull of a good roost, and to reasons no one has yet named repeats the same grammatical shape to pile up possible causes. The repeated structure sits inside the sentence, so it is parallelism, not anaphora, and the accumulation enacts how many reasons may be at work at once.

Polysyndeton (paragraph 5): “There is no mind, and there is nothing choosing; there is only each bird, and its seven neighbors, and the dusk coming on.”

The closing only each bird, and its seven neighbors, and the dusk coming on adds and's where none are needed. This is polysyndeton, the deliberate opposite of the asyndeton in the first paragraph: the extra conjunctions slow the line to a stop and give each of the three plain things its own weight.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the third paragraph, the comparison of the tightening flock to 'a bruise spreading under skin' primarily serves to
 - A) give the flock's sudden, spreading reaction a precise and physical image
 - B) suggest that the flock has been injured by the diving falcon
 - C) register the writer's sympathy for the hunted birds
 - D) compare the starlings unfavorably with their predator
2. The writer follows the long sentence describing the flock's motion with the short sentence 'It has no leader.' This juxtaposition primarily functions to
 - A) stress that the flock's intricate order arises without anything directing it
 - B) signal that the writer will next explain how a leader is chosen
 - C) concede that the flock's movements are ultimately random
 - D) summarize a scientific debate introduced earlier in the passage

Multiple choice answer key:

1. **Answer A.** The simile translates an abstract speed-and-spread into something the reader can see. B is the too-literal trap, reading the bruise as an actual injury. C imports a sympathy the observational register never states. D invents an unfavorable comparison the line does not make.

2. Answer A. The blunt short sentence lands hard against the long one, setting the flock's visible order against the absence of any director. B inverts the passage, which insists there is no leader. C inverts the point, since the piece argues for order, not randomness. D is the wrong location: the debate appears later, in paragraph 4, with nothing earlier to summarize.

Discussion questions:

1. The writer describes the murmuration almost entirely through precise physical detail and never once calls it beautiful or amazing. How does withholding those words change the way the wonder of the scene reaches the reader?
2. Twice the writer admits the science is unsettled ('was a real puzzle until recently,' 'reasons no one has yet named'). How does admitting what is not known affect your trust in the writer as an observer?

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. By refusing the adjectives, the writer makes the reader do the marveling. The accumulating verbs (climbs, folds, pours, thins, knots) and the falcon losing its target in 'the boil of bodies' enact the wonder, so the awe feels earned by the facts rather than asserted. Telling the reader it is amazing would shrink the effect, because the reader would receive a claim instead of seeing the thing.
2. Admitting the limits of the science makes the writer more credible, not less. An observer who claims to have explained everything invites doubt; one who says the safety theory is only 'part of it' and that some reasons are still unnamed sounds like someone reporting honestly from inside a real question. The candor signals that the precise claims, like the seven neighbors, can be trusted because the writer marks where the knowledge stops.

Writing prompt (homework or extended in-class, Q2 rhetorical analysis):

Write an essay analyzing how the writer uses imagery, sentence variety, and a restrained, observational tone to convey the wonder and the order of a starling murmuration without ever asserting that it is wondrous.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- Students often label both list-sentences the same way. Paragraph 1's 'climbs, folds, pours sideways...' is asyndeton: the conjunctions are dropped to speed the rhythm. Paragraph 5's 'each bird, and its seven neighbors, and the dusk coming on' is polysyndeton: the extra and's slow it down. The two are opposites, not the same device.
- Students may read 'darkens like a bruise spreading under skin' as a claim that the birds are hurt. It is a simile for the speed and spread of the flock's turn, not a literal injury.
- Students may call 'Thousands of separate animals, and not one collision; total panic, and perfect order' parallelism. The point of the line is the opposition between its halves, so it is antithesis: contrasting ideas set in balanced form.
- Students may treat the short sentence 'It has no leader' as throwaway. It is a telegraphic sentence placed for emphasis, landing the piece's central fact hard against the long sentence before it.

AP exam alignment:

Q2 rhetorical-analysis value: a clean model of wonder conveyed through precise detail rather than asserted with adjectives. Strong for teaching asyndeton against polysyndeton, a simile read in context rather than literally, antithesis as a structural engine, the telegraphic sentence as emphasis, and how a writer's candor about uncertainty builds credibility. The wide swing between short declaratives and long accumulating sentences is a clear lesson in how sentence length creates effect.